



# Botswana

Landlocked in the heart of southern Africa, Botswana boasts the world's largest inland river delta. Diamonds provide potential wealth, but the country is crippled by HIV/AIDS.



## GEOGRAPHY

Lies on vast plateau, high above sea level. Hills in the east. Kalahari Desert in center and southwest. Swamps and salt pans elsewhere and in Okavango Basin.



## CLIMATE

Dry and prone to drought. Summer wet season, April–October. Winters are warm, with cold nights.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The nomadic San bushmen, the first inhabitants, are marginalized. One in four adults are living with HIV/AIDS; only Swaziland is worse affected. Life expectancy is around 50 years. Diamond revenue has widened wealth inequalities.



**INSIGHT:** Water, Botswana's most precious resource, is honored in the name of the currency – pula



## THE ECONOMY

Overreliance on diamonds: vulnerable to world price fluctuations. Beef is exported to Europe. Tourism aimed at wealthy wildlife enthusiasts. AIDS is devastating the population.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Botswana

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1966

**CAPITAL:** Gaborone

**POPULATION:** 1.95 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 231,803 sq. miles  
(600,370 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 9 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Setswana, English\*, Shona, San, Khoikhoi, isiNdebele

**RELIGIONS:** Traditional beliefs 50%, Christian (mainly Protestant) 30%, other (including Muslim) 20%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Tswana 98%, other 2%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Pula = 100 thebe